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From the editor-in-chief

India faces a growing crisis of food inflation and the Government is feeling the heat. From the UPA coming to power in May 2004 to December last year the retail price of sugar has risen from Rs 17 to over Rs 44 a kilo and that of the common pulse tur dal from Rs 30 to Rs 90.

In one year prices have increased by 19.75 per cent, the highest in eleven years. The Union agriculture minister is seen as the villain of the piece: the BJP wants him sacked and Mayawati has written to the prime minister demanding his resignation. There has been poor perception management, ranging from indiscreet statements about imports and the possibility of a shortage of milk. All this has left consumers confused, profiteers delighted and the intentions of the food minister under suspicion. Further, governments across all states have done nothing to either prevent hoarding or control the panic.

As the Minister of Agriculture, Sharad Pawar is responsible for output and as food minister he is responsible for controlling prices. The twin roles have been found in conflict. Every time Agriculture Minister Pawar raises procurement prices, Food Minister Pawar suffers the consequences. Not surprisingly, today he is the target of public and political ire. The bad news is that prices won't fall just because we want them to. Not in a day, not in a week. The fundamental malaise, India's agricultural crisis, has been ignored far too long and now the chickens have come home to roost.

The reason why food costs so much is simple. Demand for food is outpacing production and nothing has been done to improve productivity. Like much else in India, the culprit for this sorry state of affairs is politics. A majority of the population is employed in agriculture yet we cannot feed ourselves. The government constantly succumbs to farmers' demands for higher procurement prices without making any effort to improve productivity and reform the public distribution system by better supply chain management at the retail level. More importantly there is precious little done to create jobs outside of agriculture to tackle the severe underemployment in this sector.

For three decades now, Indian agriculture seems caught in a time warp of the green revolution. Arable land cannot be increased but it can be improved. This has not happened. The supply chain is so badly managed that one-third of produce is wasted or just rots away. It is estimated that we lose Rs 70,000 crore worth of fruits and vegetables post-harvest.

An abysmal road network and the reluctance of states to open up the retail sector to benefit both the farmer and the consumer adds to the issue. The only group that would not benefit is middlemen and not surprisingly, the one that seems the utmost concern of the politician.

Our cover story this week is written by Managing Editor Shankkar Aiyar who says, "India is ruled by the states. There is both political and economic rationale to push farm reforms at the state level urgently. The Centre can only preach." Not a single political party in any state that depends heavily on agriculture has ever made the improvement of productivity an issue or offered a suggestion to alter the status quo. The current price rise reflects a weakness of our science and the apathy of our political class about an essential segment of our economy. India will never become a modern economy unless it modernises its agriculture.

(Aroon Purie)



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